

OZVOR • METHODOLOGY

The LLM Citation Tracker

Monitor when ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity & Gemini mention your business — in 10 minutes a week

Ozvor

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Know in 10 Minutes a Week Whether ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, Gemini and Google AI Overview Recommend Your Business

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The one-line promise: Run this 10-minute routine every week with the companion spreadsheet, and within a month you'll know — with real evidence, not a guess — whether AI answer engines are naming your business or your competitor, and exactly what to fix.

Start here: your 10-minute weekly routine

This is the whole method. Everything else in this document explains *why* it works and how to get more out of it — but you can start today with just these five steps and the companion spreadsheet, **LLM-Citation-Tracker.xlsx**.

1. **Open a fresh/incognito browser window** and log out of any AI accounts you're signed into. This gets you closer to what a stranger — your next customer — actually sees.
2. **Run your 8-10 live queries** from the **Query Bank** tab, across the engines that matter to your audience. You don't need all five every week — a sustainable default is ChatGPT + Perplexity + Gemini weekly, rotating Claude and Google AI Overview in every other week.
3. **Log one row per query, per engine** in the **Weekly Log** tab: Cited? (Y/N), Position, Source URL cited, Sentiment, Competitor cited instead, and a one-line note.
4. **Glance at the Dashboard tab.** Your citation rate, per-engine breakdown, share-of-voice vs. competitors, and sentiment mix update automatically — no formulas to touch.
5. **Close the laptop.** Same day, every week. Ten minutes.

Do this for **four weeks** and you'll have a trend you can trust — a single run is a snapshot; the pattern over weeks is the signal.

Next step: Want this done for you, automatically, across all five engines? **Start a free AI Visibility Test at ozvor.com/test** — see your score in under two minutes, no credit card required.

Why this matters (the short version)

For twenty years, getting found online meant ranking on Google. Now AI answer engines sit *on top of* search — ChatGPT reached roughly 900 million weekly users in February 2026 (OpenAI, via TechCrunch), and Google's AI Overviews reach 2 billion+ people a month (Alphabet, Jul 2025). These engines don't return ten blue links. They return two or three names.

68% of US Google searches ended without a click in early 2026, up from about 60% in 2024 (SparkToro / Rand Fishkin, Jun 2026). The clicks aren't moving to page two — they're disappearing into the answer itself.

The gap is real and measurable for small businesses specifically:

- **ChatGPT recommends only about 1.2% of local business locations** it's asked about (SOCi 2026 Local Visibility Index).
- **Roughly 87% of independent HVAC and plumbing contractors have effectively zero AI citation share** (5WPR HVAC & Plumbing AI Visibility Index, Q1 2026), while a handful of national franchises absorb the leads.
- Brands cited inside a Google AI Overview earn **about 120% more organic clicks** than uncited brands on the same query (Seer Interactive, Apr 2026), and AI-referred visitors sign up at up to **11x** the rate of search visitors on some sites (Microsoft Clarity, Nov 2025) — though a separate 54-site study found no statistically significant average difference (Amsive, 2026). The honest read: AI visitors *often* convert better, not always.

Only about **16% of brands systematically track AI search performance** (HubSpot, citing Sep 2025 data). This tracker puts you in that minority.

The honest caveats

No engine notifies you when it names your business — there's no public API for it. The only way to know is to ask, yourself, using the questions your customers would actually type. That has real limits, and you should read your own data with them in mind:

- **You only see the queries you think to run.** Untested questions are unknown territory.
- **Answers vary run to run.** ChatGPT surfaces roughly 44 different brands across 100 runs of the same prompt; only about 5 show up 80%+ of the time (Search Engine Land / Fishkin, Feb 2026). One sample is a snapshot, not a verdict.
- **Personalization skews results.** A fresh, logged-out session gets you closer to what a stranger sees.
- **"Mentioned" and "cited with a link" are different things.** Track both — an engine can name you without linking, or link a source without naming you in the prose.

This isn't a perfect instrument. It's the best free, honest, do-it-yourself one that exists — and it gives you genuine, unmediated feedback no dashboard can fake.

The five engines you're tracking

Engine	What to know	Where it tends to pull from
ChatGPT	~900M weekly users (OpenAI, Feb 2026). Runs live web search on only ~34.5% of queries; the rest answer from training memory (Siana Marketing, Q1 2026).	Wikipedia, Reddit, homepages, news, plus live search when triggered.
Perplexity	Answer-first, and almost always shows its sources — the easiest place to see <i>which URL</i> it cited.	Reddit is its #1 cited domain (Profound, 2026).
Claude	Conversational, increasingly used for research and B2B decisions.	Authoritative, well-structured sources; cites less visibly than Perplexity.
Gemini	750M+ monthly users (Alphabet, Q4 2025). Grounded in Google's index and Maps for local.	Google Search results and Google Business Profile — most accurate for local.
Google AI Overview	Not a chatbot — the AI answer box on top of normal Google results, 2B+ monthly users. Worth tracking as a 5th engine.	The live Google index; favors content that already ranks.

Why this is winnable for a small business: a peer-reviewed study from Princeton, Georgia Tech and the Allen Institute for AI (KDD 2024, arXiv:2311.09735) tested 9 tactics across 10,000 queries and found credible quotations (+41%), concrete statistics (+33%), and citing authoritative sources (+28% on average, up to +115% for an underdog page) each lift a page's visibility in AI answers. Keyword stuffing was the one tactic that backfired (−8.7%). AI rewards the clearest, best-sourced, most current answer — something a focused small business can win.

Building a query bank that reflects real customers

The single biggest mistake people make: testing their own business name. Customers who already know your name aren't the ones you're worried about. **Write each query the way a customer would phrase it when they don't know you exist yet.**

Build your bank across three intent stages, because they behave differently:

1. **Discovery** — broad, "who even does this" questions. *"Best bookkeeper for a small e-commerce business."* Hardest to win, most valuable when you do.
2. **Consideration** — "how do I choose / what should I look for" questions. *"What should I ask a photographer before hiring them for brand work?"* GEO gold — a good FAQ post can get cited even with a tiny following.
3. **Decision** — specific, ready-to-act, local or product-specific. *"Same-day cosmetic dentist consultation in [your city]."* High commercial intent.

A practical recipe (10–15 live queries, rotating 8–10 each week): 3–4 discovery + 3–4 consideration + 3–4 decision + 1–2 competitor-shaped queries ("alternatives to [the big chain in my category]") to see who the AI defaults to.

The read-aloud test: say the query out loud. If it sounds like something a stranger would type to find a service like yours, it belongs in your bank. If it sounds like a press release about your company, cut it.

The companion spreadsheet's **Query Bank** tab ships **30+ ready-made, customer-style queries across ten verticals** (dentist, accountant/bookkeeper, law firm, HVAC/plumber, restaurant, SaaS consultant, photographer, designer, fitness/PT, real estate) — adapt the bracketed fill-ins, like [your city] , and start running them.

Reading what you find

Every result carries four signals. The Weekly Log tab turns each one into a dropdown column so you're never guessing at the format:

- 1. **Cited? (Y/N)** — the primary signal. "Cited" means your business is named in the prose *or* your content is linked as a source. Be strict: a generic mention of your category is not a citation of you.
- 2. **Position** — 1 / 2 / 3 / list / none . Being named first is worth far more than being buried fourth in a long, unranked list. The trend over weeks tells you whether you're climbing toward the default answer or slipping.
- 3. **Sentiment** — positive / neutral / negative / inaccurate . "Inaccurate" is the most actionable flag: wrong city, a dropped service, the wrong specialty — it means the engine is pulling from stale or thin content you can fix by publishing something better.
- 4. **Source cited** — which URL got linked (Perplexity and ChatGPT Search show this most). This tells you exactly which piece of your content the AI is retrieving, so you know what to publish more of. Log competitor URLs too — you're mapping the real battlefield.

What a month of tracking looks like

A realistic pattern for a business doing consistent GEO content: nothing for the first couple of weeks, then a first citation once new content gets indexed and trusted.

Week	Query	Engine	Cited?	Position	Notes
1	Best Invisalign consult in [city]	Perplexity	N	none	3 competitor clinics named
2	Best Invisalign consult in [city]	Perplexity	N	none	Same 3 clinics, still no citation
3	Best Invisalign consult in [city]	Perplexity	Y	list	Linked a LinkedIn post published two weeks earlier
4	Best Invisalign consult in [city]	Perplexity	Y	2	Climbed from list to #2; now citing an owned page

That climb — none → list → #2 — is exactly what working GEO looks like.

How to act on the pattern

- **Cited consistently at #1-2, accurate, positive.** You own this query. Keep the cited content fresh — AI-cited URLs run about 26% fresher on average than top organic results (Ahrefs, ~17M citations, Dec 2025) — and re-use the format on adjacent queries.
- **Cited sometimes, stuck in "list."** You're in the door but not the default. Strengthen the exact content being retrieved: add a credible quotation, a concrete statistic, an authoritative citation — the three tactics proven to move visibility most. Answer the question directly in a self-contained 50-150 word section.
- **Never cited; a competitor always is.** Study what they publish for that query and out-answer it — more specific, more current, better sourced. Note *where* they're cited from (often Reddit, LinkedIn, a review profile, an FAQ page) and show up credibly there too.
- **Cited but inaccurate.** Treat as urgent. Publish accurate, dated content stating the correct facts plainly, and make sure your Google Business Profile — which feeds Gemini and AI Overviews — is correct.
- **Cited but negative.** Read the surrounding context, address the underlying issue, and build a counterweight of accurate, well-sourced content. Don't argue with the model; change its inputs.

The throughline: **AI cites the clearest, most credible, most current answer it can find.** Your job is to be that answer for the queries that turn into customers.

Quick answers

Do I need all five engines every week? No. Rotate — ChatGPT, Perplexity and Gemini weekly, with Claude and Google AI Overview every other week — enough to catch real trend shifts without doubling your time.

What if I don't have 8-10 queries ready yet? Start with the 3 queries most likely to bring you a real customer this month and grow the list from there. A smaller, honest bank beats a large, sloppy one.

Nothing showed up in week one — is that normal? Yes. Most businesses see zero citations for the first week or two, especially on decision-stage queries. That's the baseline you're trying to move, not a sign the method failed.

Should I test my own business name? Only as a sanity check, not as your main bank. Customers who already know you by name aren't the ones you're trying to reach with this tracker.

How do I know if I'm imagining the trend? Don't trust a single week. Four consecutive weeks on the same query is what turns "maybe" into a real, actionable pattern.

When to graduate to automated monitoring

The spreadsheet is genuinely useful, and for a single-location business testing a handful of queries it may be all you need for a while. But it has a real ceiling:

- **Coverage.** Ten minutes covers ~10 queries. Real categories have hundreds of phrasings you can't manually test with confidence.
- **Consistency.** One person, once a week, is subject to fatigue and "did I actually run that incognito?" Answers vary run to run, so a single weekly sample is statistically thin.
- **Benchmarking.** Tracking share-of-voice by hand across multiple rivals and five engines gets unmanageable fast.

- **What to publish next.** The spreadsheet tells you *that* you're invisible. It doesn't score your overall standing or write the fix for you.

Ozvor audits how your brand appears across ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, Gemini and Google AI Overview, computes your Ozvor AI Visibility Score, benchmarks you against competitors, and builds a GEO content plan — the automated version of everything in this document.

The full Ozvor path

Step	Offer	Price	What it does
1	Free AI Visibility Test — ozvor.com/test	Free	See your citation status against one competitor in under 2 minutes. No credit card.
2	The Get-Cited Kit	\$29 one-time	A full audit, your top 3 fixes, and 3 ready-to-publish drafts (blog, LinkedIn, FAQ).
3	Growth — ozvor.com/pricing	\$99/mo	Automates this weekly tracking for you across all 5 engines — citation rate, position, sentiment, competitor share-of-voice, and a GEO content plan, with nothing to log by hand.
4	Agency — ozvor.com/agencies	\$249/mo	Growth's monitoring across up to 25 client brands, with white-label reports.
5	OrganicPosts by Ozvor — ozvor.com/organicposts	Done-for-you	We write and publish the citation-worthy content for you.

Start this week

Open a fresh browser tab, pull 8-10 queries from the Query Bank tab, and log your first week. In four weeks you'll know exactly where you stand.

Want it automated instead of run by hand? Start free at **ozvor.com/test** — no credit card, results in minutes. Questions: **hello@ozvor.com**.

Sources & references

The methodology in this tracker is grounded in named, dated, public research. Full URLs below so every figure is verifiable.

Why measurement is needed (the scale of AI search)

- OpenAI / ChatGPT — 900M weekly active users (Feb 2026), via TechCrunch — <https://techcrunch.com/2026/02/27/chatgpt-reaches-900m-weekly-active-users/>
- Google AI Overviews — 2B monthly users, via TechCrunch — <https://techcrunch.com/2025/07/23/googles-ai-overviews-have-2b-monthly-users-ai-mode-100m-in-the-us-and-india/>
- Pew Research Center — AI summaries and link clicks (Jul 2025) — <https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2025/07/22/google-users-are-less-likely-to-click-on-links-when-an-ai-summary-appears-in-the-results/>

- SparkToro / Rand Fishkin — 2026 zero-click study — <https://sparktoro.com/blog/in-2026-less-than-one-third-of-google-searches-still-send-a-click/>

What to measure, and why answers vary run-to-run

- Aggarwal et al., "GEO: Generative Engine Optimization", KDD 2024 — arXiv:2311.09735 · <https://arxiv.org/abs/2311.09735>
- Search Engine Land — repeated ChatGPT runs & brand visibility (~5 brands per category) — <https://searchengineland.com/repeated-chatgpt-runs-brand-visibility-468552>
- Cyrus Shepard / Zyppy — AI citation ranking factors — <https://signal.zyppy.com/p/ai-citation-ranking-factors>

Where citations come from (what to watch by source)

- Siana Marketing — where ChatGPT gets its information (2026) — <https://www.sianamarketing.com/resources/where-does-chatgpt-get-its-information-2026-report>
- Peec AI — most-cited domains, via Search Engine Land — <https://searchengineland.com/ai-search-engines-cite-reddit-youtube-and-linkedin-most-study-473138>
- Semrush — most-cited domains, 3-month tracking — <https://www.semrush.com/blog/most-cited-domains-ai/>
- Profound — Reddit & AI search — <https://www.tryprofound.com/blog/the-data-on-reddit-and-ai-search>

*Ozvor — the AI Search visibility platform for SMBs and agencies. Audit how you appear across ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, Gemini & Google AI Overview; get your Ozvor AI Visibility Score; benchmark competitors; build a GEC content plan. Start free at **ozvor.com** · **hello@ozvor.com**. Done-for-you execution via OrganicPosts by Ozvor.*